

Do human rights meaningfully exist in Nigeria?

Human rights exist in Nigeria, at least on paper. They are written into the Constitution, recited in official speeches, and cited whenever the country wants to appear democratic. The rights to life, dignity, liberty, fair hearing, and freedom of expression are all clearly guaranteed. Legally speaking, the framework exists. The problem is not the absence of rights, but their absence in real life. **For many Nigerians, human rights violations are not rare scandals; they are routine experiences.** Police brutality, unlawful arrests, prolonged detention without trial, gender-based violence, insecurity caused by armed groups, and extrajudicial killings are not abstract concepts. They are stories people live with, recover from, or die from.



Young Nigerians have either experienced human rights abuses directly or witnessed them through videos and testimonies circulating online. Social media did not create these violations; it simply exposed what had long been ignored. The #EndSARS movement made that reality impossible to deny. What began as a protest against the Special Anti-Robbery Squad a police unit widely accused of extortion, torture, illegal detention, and extrajudicial killings quickly became something larger. It was not just about one unit; it was about a system that had normalized abuse and impunity. Young Nigerians took to the streets to say what had been whispered for years: enough is enough. The state's response to excessive force, arrests, intimidation, and denial revealed a deeper contradiction.

A country that guarantees the right to protest, yet violently suppresses those who exercise it, is not protecting rights; it is protecting itself from accountability by silencing dissent.



Freedom of expression is constitutionally guaranteed, yet it often comes with consequences. Journalists are harassed, activists are monitored, and ordinary citizens are arrested for social media posts or criticism of public officials. Peaceful protesters are frequently dispersed with force rather than dialogue. The message is rarely announced, but it is clearly understood you are free to speak, as long as your voice is not inconvenient.

A right that exists only when it does not challenge power is not truly a right. It is a washed up text without purpose.

The justice system reflects the same pattern. In theory, everyone is equal before the law. In practice, access to justice is shaped by wealth, political connections, and status. Court cases drag on for years, while some detainees remain in custody without trial. For the poor and powerless, enforcing basic rights often feels impossible.

When justice depends on who you know or what you can afford, human rights stop being universal and become selective privileges. Human Rights in Nigeria ought not to be imaginary because they are written in the Constitution, signed and frequently referenced.

But rights that cannot be enforced, protected, or trusted are fragile and fragility is dangerous.

Human rights do not truly exist where accountability is weak, institutions are compromised, and abuse is treated as normal. They do not exist where citizens fear the state more than they trust it.



For human rights to move beyond paper, Nigeria needs more than laws. It needs consequences for violators, independent institutions, and citizens who refuse to be conditioned into silence.

The most effective way to kill human rights is not to abolish them, but to make people believe they are lucky to have any at all. And that is a lie Nigerians must continue to reject.



Irene Osabuohien is a passionate human rights advocate committed to social justice, gender equality, and inclusion. She believes growth comes from open-mindedness and stepping beyond comfort zones to gain new perspectives. Motivated by the principles of equity and youth participation, she aspires to become a prominent human rights activist, amplifying young voices and empowering marginalized communities through the pursuit of justice and accountability. She is currently an intern in Yiaga Africa.